

CURRENT NEWS **EARLY BIRD**

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SHATTERED SHIELD

*The Decline of Russia's
Nuclear Forces*

Downsizing A Mighty Arsenal

*Moscow Rethinks Role
As Its Weapons Rust*

Second of two articles

By DAVID HOFFMAN

Washington Post Foreign Service

MOSCOW—Russia's strategic forces, the vast phalanx of nuclear-armed submarines, bombers and intercontinental ballistic missiles built during the Cold War by the Soviet Union, are suffering a dramatic decline because of arms control treaties, the Soviet breakup, looming obsolescence and Russia's economic depression.

Regardless of whether the United

States and Russia move ahead on bilateral arms-control treaties, a decade from now Russia's forces will be less than one-tenth the size they were at the peak of Soviet power, according to estimates prepared in Russia and in the West. Ten years from now, if current economic trends continue, Russia may have a strategic nuclear force just larger than that of China, and somewhat larger than Britain's and France's combined.

This slide has enormous implications for Russia and the West that are only now beginning to emerge. For Russia, the decline has raised painful dilemmas about its place in the world, underscoring yet again the erosion of its superpower status.

At the same time, while the nuclear shield is shrinking, Russian leaders have decided to rely on the deterrent power of the nuclear weapons more than ever—to compensate for their even weaker and more chaotic conventional forces. President Boris Yeltsin recently signed a new national security doctrine that enshrines this idea. Russia also has dropped its pledge not to be the first to use nuclear weapons.

"All we have is the nuclear stick," said Lev Volkov, a prominent Russian military strategist. "Of course, we should all together decrease this nuclear danger. But right now, we have nothing else. We're naked. Can you imagine that?"

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Some Russian strategists are beginning to look for an exit from the arms-race mentality of the Cold War, a way that would preserve Russia's membership in the nuclear club, perhaps even its Great Power status, but without the enormous drag on its resources. One recent proposal is for Russia simply to abandon the bilateral arms-control process with the United States and go its own way with a small, independent nuclear force.

In Moscow, leading politicians and military experts are also looking, nervously, not at the West, but at Russia's long, sparsely populated southern and eastern borders, toward China and the Islamic world, where they see the real future threats to Russian interests.

In the West, too, the decline of Russia's strategic forces could have serious repercussions, raising questions about the size and posture of U.S. forces. Some see it as a chance for the United States to pursue still-deeper cuts in nuclear weapons, including a new strategic arms agreement, that would keep Washington and Moscow at approximate balance, "locking in" the lower Russian levels with formal treaties. Also, some experts say both sides should remove the still-tense nuclear-alert posture of the Cold War.

But there is also resistance from those who urge caution. For example, in the 1994 nuclear posture review, the Clinton administration decided to create a "hedge" of warheads against the prospect of future uncertainty in Russia and to preserve the existing U.S. structure of land-sea-air forces. Some argue that, as the only global superpower, the United States does not need to match the steep Russian decline. And Russia's woes may embolden backers of building a ballistic missile defense system.

Only a decade ago, when the Soviet arsenal hit its

Cohen says Iraq must do more than open its sites

Philadelphia Inquirer...See Pg. 8

U.S. Military Commander Says Break in Conflict with Iraq May Last Awhile

Wall Street Journal...See Pg. 8

McKinney jury meets today to decide sentence

USA Today...See Pg. 9



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Pentagon Stresses Control of Space

By Walter Pincus
Washington Post
Staff Writer

Control of space has become a prime concern of Pentagon planners and policymakers as intelligence collection and weapons delivery systems become more dependent on satellites, the commander-in-chief of the U.S. Space Command told a Senate Armed Services subcommittee last week.

"Protection of our vital space systems is critical if they are going to be there for the war fighter when and where needed," Gen. Howell M. Estes III told the panel.

There are about 550 satellites now in space, Estes said, half of them American and half of those government-owned. As hundreds of U.S. intelligence, communications and weapons-targeting satellites are launched over the next 10 years, "we must guard against turning our dependence into a vulnerability," Estes said.

Although both the White House and Congress agree with Estes that control of space has become critical to national security, they disagree over the right course to accomplish that mission. Two key congressmen, for example, object to the Clinton administration halting funding for three anti-satellite (ASAT) programs.

At last week's hearing, Robert C. Smith (R-N.H.), chairman of the Armed Services panel, and Sen. James M. Inhofe (R-Okla.) questioned why President Clinton used his line-item veto last October to kill technology research that could have led to two ASAT weapons systems. They asked whether the veto was part of secret negotiations with Russia on an ASAT ban.

Estes said no such negotiations were going on or even contemplated.

Discussions have been underway with Russia on a possible reporting agreement among countries that operate ground lasers, according to Robert G. Bell, a National Se-

curity Council specialist on defense policy and arms control.

Bell said in an interview that the program, which would deal with ground-based lasers aimed above the horizon, would be much like the reporting system now used for intercontinental ballistic missile tests, where warnings are given by the launching country so that planes and ships stay away from areas where dummy warheads are aimed.

Under the proposed U.S. space laser agreement, laser operators in Russia and elsewhere could ask the U.S. Space Command, which maintains coverage of all items in space, whether the use of laser illumination in a particular area of space at a specific time might inadvertently hit an orbiting object such as a nation's satellite, space shuttle or space station. Space Command already runs such a clearinghouse for American laser operators.

"If such an agreement were reached with Russia," Bell wrote in a recent letter delivered to the subcommittee, "no details about the vulnerabilities of our satellites need or would be divulged."

Bell said the impetus for these discussions came from the recent test of the low-power U.S. ground-based Miral laser. Although the beam did not destroy the target satellite, it did affect one or more of the target's sensors, Bell said. Estes told the subcommittee that after the Miral test, Russian President Boris Yeltsin suggested future experiments should not be conducted against other country's space vehicles.

Treaties and laws are already in place to protect the satellites of the United States and other nations, Bell said. For example, under a 1971 agreement, neither the United States or Russia can interfere with each other's space-based missile early warning systems.

But such obligations are not binding in the event of war or self-defense, Bell said.

Smith and Inhofe also questioned the Pentagon's elimina-

tion of funding for concept work on an Air Force space plane, similar to the space shuttle, that could destroy enemy satellites.

Estes and the subcommittee's other witness, Keith Hall, director of the National Reconnaissance Office, told the senators they had not been consulted before the president's vetoes. Both said there could have been benefits gained from the three programs that were halted.

However, Estes and Hall testified that more advanced technical efforts were underway designed to protect the space system. "There is no single solution for space control," Hall said.

Bell said the canceled programs represented older technologies that, if developed, would have been used to destroy satellites. Today, Bell said, the United States is looking at new approaches that instead destroy the downlinked ground station of the enemy's satellites. The goal is to shut off access to that data without destroying transmissions to neutral third parties.

One project that provides such a challenge is the nation's \$15 billion Global Positioning System (GPS), which provides signals from a worldwide array of satellites to help civilian and commercial users worldwide.

GPS puts out two different signals. One is a navigation tool available to the public; the other, more precise signal is encrypted and used by the U.S. military.

Two years ago, Clinton announced that in order to aid worldwide commercial navigation, allowing accurate landings in fog, the United States would make the more precise GPS signal publicly available by 2000, with accuracy down to less than a meter.

Since rogue states or U.S. enemies could benefit from

this, the president ordered the Pentagon to develop a countermeasure that would enable the Air Force to jam the GPS signal locally in the event of hostilities. At the same time, the Pentagon has to make certain that GPS isn't vulnerable to an enemy's deception.

The task has proven so complex that Estes expects he may need until 2006 before the president's promise of a fully open GPS can be fulfilled.

Meanwhile, Estes and Hall outlined some of the new satellite systems that are being developed. Infrared satellites, operating in high and low orbits, are being prepared for deployment to give warning about missiles launched anywhere in the world, determine where they are going to land and aim defensive weapons to knock them down, Estes said.

Another new space-based system, the ground-moving target indicator, would spot enemy targets moving on the ground and immediately signal for U.S. weapons to be aimed in the area. That system may be tested within the next five years, according to Hall.

To "enforce the peace" in space, Estes said, the United States will need a surveillance system that can look at other satellites and be able to detect any change in their configurations to see if they have become threats to U.S. space vehicles.

To meet that threat, Estes said, defense systems will be needed to "identify the appropriate target, select the correct response, direct 'negation' actions and assess the effect of those actions."

At the same time, he said, these weapons must avoid collateral effects on third-party satellites, not permanently damage the space environment and avoid destroying our own systems.

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Iraq Urges U.S. to Normalize Relations

BAGHDAD, Iraq—In a change from its usual anti-American rhetoric, Iraq urged the United States to "courageously" change its policies and normalize relations with Baghdad.

An editorial in the state-run Baghdad Observer said that such a move by President Clinton and British Prime Minister Tony Blair would be in their political and economic interests.

Washington Times
March 16, 1998 Pg. 10

INSIDE THE RING

by Ernest Blazar

Security scorecards

Rep. Ike Skelton, Missouri Democrat, wanted a clear answer last week. During a House National Security Committee hearing March 12, he asked the Army, Navy, Air Force and Marine service chiefs to respond to his question with a one-word answer.

It was the Joint Chiefs' first joint congressional appearance this year.

On a 1-to-10 scale, with one being the low point of the "hollow force" of 1978-79 and 10 being the 1991 high point after the Persian Gulf War, "in your personal and professional opinion, how do you rate your service overall?"

Army Gen. Dennis Reimer: "Eight."

Navy Adm. Jay Johnson: "Eight."

Air Force Gen. Michael Ryan: "Seven point nine."

Marine Gen. Chuck Krulak: "Eight plus."

Faintest praise

There is no such thing as a "pink slip" when you are secretary of the Army, Navy or Air Force. An outright firing of such people creates an unneeded ruckus. It's better they leave on their own. After all, such high-ranking positions are supposed to be filled by men and women smart enough to know when they aren't wanted anymore.

Consider the Clinton administration's service secretaries.

Togo D. West Jr., was appointed Army secretary Nov. 22, 1993, and left the post to become head of the Department of Veterans Affairs last year.

Sheila E. Widnall, a Massachusetts Institute of Technology pro-

fessor, was appointed Air Force secretary Aug. 6, 1993. After four years, she returned to the school in 1997.

John Dalton was appointed Navy secretary July 22, 1993. So far, he has announced no plans to leave the job. But to hear the Pentagon's official spokesman publicly tell it, there's no one exactly asking him to stay aboard.

Here's the story.

Pentagon officials are looking for a successor to Mr. West as Army secretary. One of the folks contacted for the job is Rep. Paul McHale, Pennsylvania Democrat. He told them no, but the former Marine said he would like to be considered for Navy secretary if the slot ever opened.

The Navy secretary oversees not just the Navy, but also the Marine Corps.

Well, such an opening may be in the works, the congressman was told. "I believe the response was that people generally don't serve as service secretaries for eight years," Pentagon spokesman Kenneth Bacon told reporters last Thursday. "The terms tend to be in the range of several years." He pointedly reminded reporters that "both Secretary West and Secretary Widnall left at about the time their first term ended."

That, of course, prompted a reporter to ask if Navy Secretary Dalton is on his way out.

"I've just explained the state of play and that's where it stands right now," said Mr. Bacon. "We have a secretary of the Navy and we have somebody who would make a good secretary of the Navy if there's a vacancy."

Notably absent was any indication from Mr. Bacon that Mr. Dalton is welcome to stay. And the government rarely advertises its intended replacements for top officials who haven't announced their intention to leave office. Together, this is what is called "sending signals" in Washington. Nose to the trail, a reporter pressed, "Has Secretary Dalton

indicated to Secretary [of Defense William S.] Cohen that he intends to leave any time soon?" "I don't know the answer to that question," Mr. Bacon told Pentagon reporters. And then the freeze-out: "I haven't spoken to Secretary Dalton about it."

Top secrets

About \$14 billion of the Pentagon's \$250 billion budget request this year is for secret and unacknowledged purposes, called "black programs," according to the Center for Strategic and Budgetary Assessments.

Mostly, such money goes to programs like spy satellites, cryptology, and state-of-the-art weapons programs like the F-117A stealth attack jet and B-2 bomber, both of which started in the "black world."

This year's budget request for secret programs is less than the \$21 billion peak in the middle of the Reagan defense buildup. But when inflation is considered, it's really about half the peak level, the not-for-profit defense think tank figured.

To arrive at the figure, analysts combed line by line through the defense budget looking for odd-sounding code-names like LINK PLUMERIA and SHORTSTOP.

Testimonial

"The term 'hollowness' is not descriptive of the Army today. The Army of today consists of great quality soldiers and civilians led by competent, well-trained leaders equipped with the best equipment found anywhere in the world. Personnel shortages and turbulence in the field do exist." — Lt. Gen. Thomas Burnette, deputy Army chief of staff for operations and plans, March 11, before the House National Security Subcommittee on readiness.

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Navy Times

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Pg. 2

Navy secretary not leaving soon

Rep. Paul McHale, D-Pa., is on Defense Secretary William Cohen's short list to head the Navy Department or occupy another high defense post, a Pentagon spokesman said March 12.

But Navy secretary John H. Dalton says he has no plans to leave.

When Togo West stepped down as Army secretary last year, McHale turned down an offer by Bob Tyrer, Cohen's chief of staff, to take over the Army department, said Pen-

tagon spokesman Kenneth Bacon. Instead, McHale, a former Marine, expressed interest in the Navy's top civilian post, should it come open.

But a spokesman for Dalton said the secretary, who has held the job since 1993, isn't going anywhere.

"I've heard him say several times that he's got the best job in government," said Dalton spokesman Navy Capt. Craig Quigley.

Said Bacon, "If there were a change, . . . Rep. McHale would certainly be a strong candidate for consideration as Secretary of the Navy, and that's where it stands."